
The time factor

Taking two to three days a month to get the job done is a popular newbie approach. If you find you are one of the few people who can keep this up month after month without having a nervous breakdown, congratulations! Taking on too much in the beginning and ending up in tears at hour 13 is no way to feel warm and fuzzy about assembly cooking. Believe me, I've tried it. Develop a system that works for you in order to be consistent.

Go flat

If you've been assembly-cooking at home for a while now, this may seem like sort of a no-brainer to you. But you'd be surprised at the number of people who whip up large batches of pasta sauce, only to bag it up and toss it on a freezer shelf. Ever try to pry a bag of spaghetti sauce from a shelf after it has frozen haphazardly around the various wire rungs? Not a good way to psych yourself up for a second round. If you are using the freezer bags for the bulk of your perishable freezer meals, fill each about three-quarters full, seal the bags, and then stack them flat. Once they are frozen, you can either keep them there and pull from the stack, or stack them vertically and grab individual

bags like you would folders from a medical shelf. Slick.

Sex it up

As with bulk buying, it helps to set yourself up for success. Include some gourmet entrées the first month, do some fun mozzarella stick appetizers, or try some DIY pull-apart cookie dough. Some of my favorites are eggplant parmesan and knockoff versions of dips and appetizers from various popular chain restaurants.

The container principle

Also great for successful small space living, this is a strategy for implementing assembly cooking into your repertoire of money-saving magic tricks. In the case of snack-sized bagged items or dry ingredient kits, putting all of the bags into a larger container or gallon-sized zipper bag is helpful. A similar concept could be applied to make-ahead bread mixes.

Themed prep sessions

This is basically where you do massive meal prepping based on an abundance of a particular item. For example, if potatoes go on sale, you could make mountains of mashed potatoes and save the scooped-out prebaked potato skins in freezer bags for a DIY appetizer later on. Snag a once-a-year